

of YYYY.MM (unlike our earlier releases), so our next targeted “stable” release should be 2010.09. Currently, we are doing heavy testing. By doing the testing ourselves, we can hold off problematic upgrades which could lead to an unstable system, like the recent Xorg18 upgrade. We are presently testing how the new Xorg performs, and if we think it’s good to go, we will push it to our ArchBang tree.

As far as the release schedule is concerned, we have decided on at least a twice-yearly release (with no fixed release months; only when it’s ready). We recommend that novice users do not do system upgrades of ArchBang on a rolling basis; you can install whatever packages you need through *Pacman* or *Packer* (for AUR packages), but until the next stable release, do not do a system upgrade. If you upgrade after installing ArchBang, that’s at your discretion, but you are then responsible for any further issues. While we aim at fixing those issues through forums and the bug-tracker, and by supplying patches and fixes—immediately after you break something, you are essentially on your own while you try to revive your system. Take note that we are indeed recommending a “fresh install twice a year” approach, like Ubuntu, for novice Linux users. I think this is absolutely justified, as many other major distributions like Slackware or Debian follow this pattern of only releasing stable products which are highly tested. Thus, ArchBang has the distinction of having both the properties of rolling-release and scheduled-release distributions—and thus can be used by both experts and novice users!

The evolution of ArchBang Linux

The people behind ArchBang are all humble Arch Linux users, or “Archers” as Arch users are often called. Initially, Willensky Aristide (willxtreme) built a 32-bit ArchBang Live CD, and posted it in the Arch Linux forums. From that single thread, we now have our own:

- Website (<http://archbang.org>)
- Forum (<http://archbang.x.am>)
- Bug Tracker (<http://bugs.archbang.org/>)
- Git Hub (<http://gitorious.org/archbang/archbang>)
- IRC (the unofficial channel is [irc.freenode.org #archbang](#), which is open for public access. The developers do hang out there sometimes, and I participate rarely; we rely on our forum for interacting with our users. For now, IRC activity is low—if there’s a need, we may register an official channel in the future.)
- Hosting (by team member MikeT)
- Twitter account (<http://twitter.com/archbang>)

After ArchBang 1.02 was released, there was a huge demand for a 64-bit version. This is where I, personally (Pritam Dasgupta a.k.a. PDG/sHyLoCk), stepped in. I offered to build the 64-bit version of ArchBang. From there, I realised what more we could do instead of just being another Live CD distribution. I took leadership of the project from there, and started improving it based on the voluminous feedback and suggestions from our users. We received a huge response—the kind we never expected—from not

only Archers, but also from Ubuntu users and those of other Linux distributions.

For a while now, Arch Linux has been in the top 10 in Distrowatch.com rankings, but perhaps many users were avoiding it due to its challenging set-up process. Will and I worked together on releases up to version 1.05, which was still just a Live CD distribution. Will is in charge of the 32-bit version, and I’m in charge of 64-bit development.

There was a heavy demand for an installer, and I had initially thought of creating a shiny new installer written in Zenity and Bash, but the idea seemed to be against The Arch Way which we are so fond of; even senior Arch Linux members and developers suggested we keep the Arch installer as-is. We decided that ArchBang should not follow in the footsteps of Ubuntu and try to make it elementary to install, but should encourage users to learn how to set up their system. This way, ArchBang doesn’t rob the user of the learning experience in installing Arch Linux! Installing Xorg and Openbox separately is not much of an education—the real education is how to install and maintain your Arch system.

Hence, I started hacking the `/arch/setup` script from the 2009.02 release of Arch Linux. It was done within a few days, and on 27th February 2010, we released ArchBang 2.00 RC1 with the installer included. At this time, there were just the two of us developing this project. After this release, a few others joined in.

Mike Tuffin (MikeT) hosts the website and custom repositories, and also created the Bug Tracker, which is based on Flyspray. Mikhail Ovchinnikov (Zafirus) and Matthew Horsell (genisis300) are our key developers now, who have generously contributed their ideas, skills, and most importantly, their time on this project! Lachlan McCracken (loki) is responsible for our logo, website (built using PmWiki) and artwork. For a full list of members in The ArchBang Team, see <http://archbang.org/Main/TheArchBangTeam>.

It is a great honour, and a euphoric feeling to work with my worldwide team. Even though we are separated by many miles due to geographical constraints, we feel at /home together while working on ArchBang, and hanging out in the forum. Open source is a great platform which not only inspires creativity, but also spreads a strong message of peace and freedom. We work without caring about the political aspects of our countries, the colour of our skin, or the religion we follow. We are all contributors, irrespective of all these factors. 

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The author is currently pursuing his MBA at IISWBM Kolkata, after a B. Tech (I.T. Engineering). An avid reader and a hard-core Linux fan, he also enjoys music and sketching. He got involved with FOSS and Linux back in 2008. He has always been a “distro-hopper”, and Arch Linux is his favourite Linux distribution. He is glad he could be a part of this Arch fork, and improve and contribute back to the Arch community. You can mail him at: pdg@archlinux.us and follow ArchBang’s progress and news at: <http://twitter.com/archbang>.